

Harit Nagpal,
MD & CEO, Tata Play

lions who still don't have access to TV might go straight to mobile. Tata Play's DTH and OTT bundle is good, but it totally depends on how it is priced," says Sinha.

Tata Play offers a 50-mbps speed plan at ₹850 per month. However, users can bring the effective price below ₹500 per month by choosing to pay for 12 months together. Rival JioFiber, Reliance Jio's broadband service, comes with a base plan of ₹399 per month, which offers 30-mbps speeds with a FUP (fair usage policy) limit of up to 3.3 TB. On the other hand, Airtel's Xstream Fiber connection offers a 'basic' pack of 40 mbps at ₹499 per month.

"In the DTH business, we have a presence in 18 million homes with an ARPU (average revenue per user) of ₹146... Free Dish continues to disrupt the business model as good content continues to be offered for free in vast waves of the country. At the same time, the irony is that the opportunity to convert and upgrade from cable is massive. There is also a huge opportunity to monetise OTT content and deliver a unified connected experience through Airtel Xstream," Gopal Vittal, CEO, Bharti Airtel, said in a recent investor call.

According to Media Partners Asia, the growth of pay TV and DTH has been hampered by Free Dish, which is outside the purview of the New Tariff Order. No fee needs to be paid for a free-to-air (FTA) channel by a distributor such as DD Free Dish while private DTH operators have to pay maximum retail price to the broadcasters to distribute these channels to subscribers. DTH players have called it discriminatory and unfair. "We're not questioning licence fees. We're basically asking not to tax a technology if a cable operator is distributing the same technology at the same price with the same margin.



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Regulated by the same regulator, why am I paying 8 per cent and he's paying zero per cent?" asks Nagpal. Mihir Shah, Vice President, Media Partners Asia, agrees. "Over the years, migration of increasing number of pay channels to FTA has strengthened the consumer proposition of Free Dish, making it challenging for private DPOs (distribution platform operators) to grow at the same pace," he says, adding that the biggest challenge for DTH is the regulation itself. "There has to be a level playing field on regulations for traditional and new alternative modes of video distribution."

TELEVISION STILL RULES

According to IBEF (Indian Brand Equity Foundation), television is one of the largest and fastest-